

# BEYOND THE CREST

*Season 1 Storylines — Document 08*

*A Daytime Drama*

**170 episodes** • Monday, January 5 – Friday, September 4, 2026

**Tagline:** *Every crown has a price. Every secret has an heir.*

# The Shape of Season 1

Season 1 runs from Marc-Anthony's 34th birthday to Labor Day weekend on Lake Lanier, exactly fifteen years after the night he doesn't remember. The spine is one ticking clock, the Crown License deadline of 11:59 PM on August 31, and one secret: Marc-Anthony has two daughters he's never been told about.

| Movement            | Episodes    | Air dates       | What happens                                                                        |
|---------------------|-------------|-----------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| I. The Covenant     | #0001–#0030 | Jan 5 – Feb 13  | The birthday, the body in the river, the Crown License, the auditions, the elevator |
| II. Roots           | #0031–#0062 | Feb 16 – Apr 2  | Valentine's slap, Broadway, the Oscars, the DNA results, the Spare Alliance         |
| III. Blood Tests    | #0063–#0101 | Apr 6 – May 29  | Huntington's, Alvin's return, Mother's Day, the primary, Victor's 80th              |
| IV. The EGOT Summer | #0102–#0135 | Jun 1 – Jul 17  | Victor's surgery, the Tonys, Juneteenth, the kiss, the World Cup                    |
| V. Verdicts         | #0136–#0165 | Jul 20 – Aug 28 | The Club vote, the trial verdict, the Kettle unmasked, the Allegiance Clause        |
| VI. Labor Day       | #0166–#0170 | Aug 31 – Sep 4  | The deal, Theodore's arrival, the finale on Lake Lanier                             |

## Tentpoles and event episodes (the 10%)

#0001 Birthday Gala • #0011 “1958” flashback • #0031 Valentine's Ball • #0051 The Oscars • #0057 Broadway Opening Night • #0063 Easter • #0088 Mother's Day / Twins' 14th • #0096 8th-Grade Promotion • #0100 Milestone • #0101 Victor's 80th • #0106 HEIRLOOM Launch • #0107 The Tonys • #0116 Juneteenth Jubilee • #0126 Fourth of July • #0133 World Cup Semifinal • #0139 “1966” flashback • #0170 Finale. That's 17 of 170, exactly 10%.

## 1. The Crown License

*Marc-Anthony vs. Esther Smiley: the negotiation that decides whether Smiley Corporation survives.*

**Players:** Marc, Esther, Natasha, Leonard, Gus, Camille, Dorian

- Leonard reveals that 41% of Smiley revenue hangs on a deal expiring Aug 31, and Esther is named lead negotiator (#0003).
- Esther dodges Marc for six weeks, including the anonymous elevator (#0017), before they finally face off (#0030).
- The talks collapse (#0083), come back over late-night waffles (#0099), and turn personal (#0138).
- Marc offers a deal too generous to be business (#0160). They sign at 11:59 PM on Aug 31 (#0166).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** It's the first daytime love story whose love scenes are term sheets. Every romantic beat is also a corporate move worth billions.

**Status at the finale:** Signed, and both families furious that it was fair.

## 2. Roots

*Three 13-year-olds use a school heritage project and a Smiley DNA kit to discover that their “donor” father is the movie star they idolize.*

**Players:** Emma, Victoria, Lyric, Esther, Marc, Nathaniel, Trey

- Westbrook's Black History Month Roots Project assigns RootsKit tests (#0021).
- The results match the twins to Grace Bullock: aunt or half-sibling (#0053).
- “Operation Daddy”: Lyric steals a hair (#0055), the twins mail it in (#0062), and the result is a 99.98% parent/child match (#0075).
- The anonymous Father's Day card (#0117). The twins watch Marc and Esther kiss (#0126).
- They tell him themselves in the finale (#0170).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The children solve the paternity mystery before any adult does, using a product made by their own mother's company. They run the investigation, they choose the reveal, and they deliver it.

**Status at the finale:** Marc knows. Esther's secret is over.

## 3. The Spare Alliance

*The eldest grandson of each dynasty, both passed over for a younger heir, team up to destroy their golden cousins.*

**Players:** Martin, Nathaniel, Camille, Dorian, Brielle

- Nathaniel and Camille bond over losing to Esther (#0022).
- Nathaniel sees the RootsKit flag (#0056) and takes it to Martin (#0058).
- Martin's investigator proves the IVF story is fake (#0092, #0120).

- Martin hacks the Kettle account to post the blind item (#0152). Nathaniel takes it to the Smilley Family Council (#0163).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A cross-dynasty villain team whose motive is the same wound twice: being born first and chosen second.

**Status at the finale:** Nova traces the hack to Martin (#0156). Marc now knows who his enemy is.

#### 4. Who Killed T-Bone Gaines?

*A murder in the Chattahoochee pits husband against wife, father against daughter, and cousin against cousin.*

**Players:** Jeremy, Elxa, Robert, Deuce, Martin, Marc, Kane, Rosa

- The body surfaces (#0001) with “ARCHITECT” in the burner (#0002).
- Jeremy arrests Deuce, and Robert takes the case (#0015).
- The audience learns Martin did it (#0060). Peter stitched his knuckles (#0003, #0064).
- The trial (#0128–#0145). T-Bone's girlfriend swears the Architect is innocent (#0135). NOT GUILTY (#0145).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A murder mystery where the audience knows the killer halfway through, and the suspense is which family member will find out, and what they'll do.

**Status at the finale:** Deuce is free. The killer is untouched. Robert now knows who pays his bills.

#### 5. The Succession Covenant

*Victor names Marc heir apparent and promises to name his next Chairman on his 80th birthday.*

**Players:** Victor, Joan, Natasha, Jasmine, Martin, Marc, Alvin

- The Covenant (#0001). Jasmine storms Victor's study (#0002).
- Victor gives Marc the key to the 1939 press (#0009).
- The 80th birthday gala: “My successor as Chairman will be—” and Victor collapses (#0101).
- Surgery (#0102). Alvin and Jasmine move on the Crown Voting Trust while Victor is down (#0104).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The whole season's power struggle hangs on one unfinished sentence.

**Status at the finale:** Still unspoken. Theodore arrives to claim that the 1976 succession was never valid.

#### 6. The EGOT Year

*Mother and son chase the last awards they're missing in the same season.*

**Players:** Natasha, Marc, Victor, Joan, Grace, Nia, Sebastian

- Martin smears Natasha's director on Oscar eve (#0050). Natasha wins Best Actress and completes her EGOT (#0051), and Marc crashes out on a reporter.
- Marc stars in the *Sweet Chariot* revival, the role Victor originated in 1972 (#0034, #0041, #0057).
- Eleven Tony nominations (#0084). Marc wins and completes his EGOT at 34 (#0107), dedicating it “to the family I'm going to have” (#0108).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** Nobody is nerfed: in one season, the family goes from two EGOTs to four.

**Status at the finale:** Four EGOTs under one roof: Victor, Joan, Natasha, and Marc.

## 7. The Chief and the Boy Scout

*The Chief of Police protects the man she thinks is guilty, her father, while her by-the-book husband hides a genetic secret.*

**Players:** Elxa, Jeremy, Walter, Robert, Rosa, Nadia Brooks

- Elxa suspects Robert is the Architect (#0059) and destroys a ledger page to protect him (#0090–#0091).
- Jeremy's truth: his mother died of Huntington's and he has a 50% chance (#0072).
- The FBI task force (#0067). The empty warehouse raid (#0109). The marriage fractures (#0124) and they separate (#0148).
- Jeremy finally takes the test (#0155). Elxa sees Marc with Kane and understands (#0170).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A daytime heroine who is the city's top cop, protecting the wrong suspect for the right reason, while the truth is her baby brother.

**Status at the finale:** The results envelope sits unopened. Elxa knows it's Marc.

## 8. Madam President?

*The Attorney General's 2028 dream versus the reporter whose father her brother killed.*

**Players:** Arianna, Julian, Journee, Marc, Harold & Evelyn Cummings

- Arianna announces her plans (#0005). Journee starts digging (#0014).
- Journee meets Julian at a grief group (#0028). They fall in love (#0045, #0129).
- Arianna asks Marc to make Journee go away, and he refuses (#0078).
- Arianna learns Marc still has the car (#0144). Journee finds Julian's name (#0162), and Julian confesses (#0169).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A love story between a grieving daughter and the man who killed her father, played entirely in daylight.

**Status at the finale:** Journee knows. Arianna's campaign, and her secret, are on a fuse.

## 9. The Tea Kettle

*The broke filmmaker nobody takes seriously is secretly the most-read gossip blogger in Atlanta.*

**Players:** Harmony, Esther, Amond, Nathaniel, Martin

- The audience learns Harmony is Kettle in the final beat of #0001.
- Her posts drive the plot: the slap (#0032), the garden photos (#0089), Pryor's affair (#0112).
- Nathaniel funds her film to use her (#0071, #0142).
- Martin hacks her account to post the twins blind item (#0152). Esther unmasks her and a 23-year friendship ends (#0153).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The narrator of the show's own gossip is a character inside it, and the in-universe social media is a weapon.

**Status at the finale:** Harmony has lost her best friend, and she knows about the twins.

## 10. HEIRLOOM

*Grace and Mallory's beauty brand goes to war with Smilley Beauty, and Mallory falls for the enemy's grandson.*

**Players:** Grace, Mallory, Desmond, Camille, Delphine

- HEIRLOOM is announced (#0006). Mallory meets Desmond (#0019) and learns he's a Smilley (#0029).
- Camille frames Desmond (#0069). The copycat launch on Mallory's birthday (#0106).
- Desmond clears his name and quits (#0114). Mallory decides to wait for her wedding night (#0159).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A romance where the 31-year-old virgin heiress is in full control of her story, set against real corporate espionage.

**Status at the finale:** HEIRLOOM survives, and Mallory and Desmond are official.

## 11. The Primary

*Jasmine faces her first real challenge in 29 years, secretly bankrolled by the Smilleys.*

**Players:** Jasmine, Peter, Pryor, Leonard, Alvin, Morrow

- Pryor announces (#0012). The money traces back to Leonard (#0023, #0040).
- Alvin buys Pryor's secrets from Morrow (#0093). The primary goes to a runoff (#0094).
- Kettle breaks the affair story (#0112). Jasmine wins the runoff (#0113), and now owes Morrow.

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A congresswoman who wins by accepting a debt to the mob her nephew is at war with.

**Status at the finale:** Jasmine wins, but she owes Morrow.

## 12. The Vote

*Sixty-four years after Simone Donohue rejected his father, Gus Smilley applies to the Club.*

**Players:** Gus, Loretta, Joan, Victor, Lucinda

- Joan finds Gus's 1966 letter (#0039) and confronts him (#0079). The application (#0080).
- Joan confesses the romance (#0122), and Victor summons Gus (#0123).
- The “1966” flashback (#0139). The vote ties, and Joan breaks it: yes (#0140).
- Victor forgives her. “There's one more thing. About 1976” (#0158).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** A love triangle between people in their late seventies and eighties, told with the same heat as the young leads.

**Status at the finale:** The Smilleys are inside the gates. Joan has one more secret.

## 13. The Wild Card Returns

*Alvin comes home at the halfway point, and brings the underworld with him.*

**Players:** Alvin, Zion, Coco, Morrow, Marc, Jasmine

- The helicopter on the lawn (#0085). The karaoke-bar meeting with Morrow (#0086).
- Zion Reed: “I think you're my father” (#0095). DNA confirmed (#0110).
- Alvin steals the World Cup security plan (#0130). Marc sets a trap (#0131). Blackwater stops the attack (#0133).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The family's party boy is the mob's inside man, and his nephew is the mob he's betraying.

**Status at the finale:** Alvin has a son, a debt, and a very bad feeling.

## 14. The Architect's Father

*Robert Bullock realizes his son runs the Syndicate he's been defending.*

**Players:** Robert, Marc, Natasha, Kane, Cyrus

- Robert takes Deuce's case (#0015) and asks Marc for BSI footage (#0098).
- The verdict, and Kane in the gallery (#0145). Robert follows the money (#0146).
- “Then act surprised when I tell you I'm proud of you” (#0147).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The father-son scene of the year is a confession with no confession in it.

**Status at the finale:** Robert knows and is protecting him.

## 15. The Old Man

*Martin's mysterious backer is revealed in the final week: Theodore Donohue, coming home.*

**Players:** Theodore, Lorraine, Xander, Celestine, Theo III, Sienna, August, Martin, Victor

- “THE OLD MAN SAYS: PATIENCE” (#0025).
- Theodore arrives (#0167) and his family follows (#0168).
- At Summit House: “Hello, little brother” (#0170).

**Why it's never been done in daytime:** The season-long off-screen villain turns out to be family, and joins the cast the moment the audience learns who he is.

**Status at the finale:** Season 2 belongs to him.

## The Finale: Episode #0170, Friday, September 4, 2026

Labor Day weekend on Lake Lanier, fifteen years to the weekend after Marc and Esther's night. Everything collides:

- The twins walk Marc to the end of the dock: “Happy Labor Day, Dad.”
- Marc turns to Esther: “Fourteen years.” The sweetest man in the world goes still.
- Elxa sees Kane hand Marc a black river stone, and every case she ever worked rearranges itself.
- At Summit House, Theodore sets down his cane: “Hello, little brother.”
- Jeremy's Huntington's results sit unopened on the dashboard of his car.
- A gunshot echoes across the lake. Smash cut to black.

### In-universe headlines, Saturday, September 5, 2026

- **The Atlanta Beacon:** “SHOTS FIRED AT LANIER ESTATE DURING DONOHUE HOLIDAY PARTY”
- **The Peach Ledger:** “SOURCES: SMILLEY HEIR'S IVF TWINS ARE A DONOHUE MATTER”
- **Hollywood Heat:** “EGOT GOLDEN BOY'S LABOR DAY FROM HELL”
- **Social media:** #LanierShooting trends No. 1 worldwide by 1:00 AM.